

CHAPTER 8

COMPARISON / CONTRAST *similarities* *differences* PARAGRAPHS

OBJECTIVES

To write academic texts, you need to master certain skills.

In this chapter, you will learn to:

- Identify similarities and differences
- Organize comparison and contrast paragraphs
- Write supporting sentences to explain similarities and differences
- Use transition signals for comparison / contrast
- Write, revise, and edit a comparison / contrast paragraph about education in two different countries



INTRODUCTION

In Chapter 7, you learned about cause/effect paragraphs. Chapter 8 is about paragraphs that analyze similarities and differences. **Comparison / contrast** is a commonly used technique. For example, you compare and contrast courses and teachers when you decide which classes to take. You compare and contrast products and prices when you shop. In college classes, you will often have to compare and contrast. A professor in a political science class might ask you to write about the similarities and differences between two world leaders. In a literature class, you might have to compare two poems or two characters in a play. At the end of Chapter 8, you will write your own comparison / contrast paragraph.

TOPIC SENTENCES IN COMPARISON / CONTRAST PARAGRAPHS

The topic sentence of a comparison / contrast paragraph should name the topic (the two subjects that you are comparing or contrasting) and indicate the controlling idea (whether the focus of the paragraph is on similarities, differences, or both).

1. To understand 21st century education, let's examine the similarities and differences between the schools of 50 years ago and the schools of today.

2. When students are applying to colleges, they should consider differences in class size, academic standards, and tuition.

3. The Olympics of ancient Greece and the Olympics of today have three key differences.

different colleges

Mp1

Mp2

Mp3

T 1

T 2

SUPPORTING SENTENCES IN COMPARISON / CONTRAST PARAGRAPHS

In block organization, you group all the similarities together in one block and all of the differences together in one block. Look at this outline for the writing model on pages 172–173 if the writer had used block organization. Notice how the supporting details are presented.

Changes in Education for the 21st Century

Topic Sentence: To understand 21st century education, let's examine the similarities and differences between the schools of 50 years ago and the schools of today.

- A. Main Point: There are clear similarities between 20th century and 21st century schools.

1. Supporting Detail (Similarity): The basics—reading, writing, math, and science 50 years ago and today
2. Supporting Detail (Similarity): Knowledge from teachers and textbooks 50 years ago and today
3. Supporting Detail (Similarity): Goal of getting a highly paid job 50 years ago and today

- B. Main Point: However, there are significant differences between 20th and 21st century schools that show how education has changed.

1. Supporting Detail (Difference): Today computer skills and the 4Cs in addition to the basics
2. Supporting Detail (Difference): Today online classes and online research in addition to teachers and textbooks
3. Supporting Detail (Difference): Today student-directed topics of study in addition to teachers and textbooks
4. Supporting Detail (Difference): Changes in job market: in the 20th century, local economies (so workers stayed in one place and one job); in the 21st century, global economies (workers must adapt and move from job to job)

Concluding Sentences: In summary, education in the 21st century is firmly rooted in the basics of traditional education from the 1950s and 1960s. However, modern education has expanded what students learn, how they learn it, and why.

CONCLUDING SENTENCES IN COMPARISON / CONTRAST PARAGRAPHS

The conclusion of a comparison / contrast paragraph may repeat the topic sentence or restate similarities and differences. It may also give an opinion or a recommendation.

1. In conclusion, after students weigh the differences in quality and cost, they may decide to choose a smaller, less expensive college that nevertheless has high academic standards.
2. To sum up, the ancient Olympics and the modern Olympics differ in their purpose, participants, and events.

restating the main differences
opinion/recommendation
restating the main differences
FOCUS ON DIFFERENCES PARAGRAPH

ANALYZING THE MODEL

Read the model. Then answer the questions

Model

Two Varieties of English

1 Both British English and American English are commonly taught in schools around the world.

2 Although these two varieties of English are mutually understandable, there are quite a few differences between them. 3 One difference is spelling. 4 Some words are *spelt* one way in Great Britain but *spelled* another way in the United States. 5 A person goes to a British *theatre* but to an American *theater*. 6 British students *theorise*, *analyse*, and *socialise*, whereas American students *theorize*, *analyze*, and *socialize*. 7 A second area of difference is vocabulary. 8 For example, the word *college* names two very different types of schools in Great Britain and the United States—pre-university level in Great Britain and university level in the United States. 9 In addition, British university students live in *halls* on campus and in *flats* off campus, but American students live in *dormitories* on campus and in *apartments* off campus. 10 Finally, just as there are differences in spelling and vocabulary, there are many differences in pronunciation.

11 In Great Britain, the letter *a* in the words *path*, *laugh*, *aunt*, *plant*, is pronounced like the /a/ sound in *father*.

12 In the United States, in contrast, the letter *a* in the same words is pronounced like the /æ/ sound in *cat*. 13 All in all, students of English will notice the differences between the language used in Britain and in the United States, yet they are still learning the same language.



Main points = points of contrast (main different aspects between A & B)
Supporting details = detailed description about each difference (How A & B are different in that aspect, using contrast signals)

PRACTICE 4

Arranging a Comparison / Contrast Paragraph in Logical Order

Work with a partner. Read the sentences. They are not in logical comparison / contrast order. Number the sentences (1 through 11) to show the correct order.

Opposing Styles of Management

- 7 a. On the other hand, bottom-up decision-making moves slowly because of the number of people who are involved in the process.
- 4 b. In contrast, the owner of the company welcomes the opinions and suggestions of her employees in the bottom-up approach.
- 10 c. However, a result of bottom-up management is that employees feel like members of a team, so they are more likely to do whatever it takes for their company to be successful.
- 6 d. The top-down approach to management is effective when decisions have to be made quickly because they are based solely on the knowledge and desires of the boss.
- 11 e. In the end, business leaders should identify the management style that is best for their company—top-down, bottom-up, or a combination of the two. (concluding sentence with a personal opinion)
- 2 f. The first and most obvious difference between the two management styles is who makes decisions. MP1
- 8 g. The final difference, the attitude of employees, is also related to where and how decisions are made. MP3
- 5 h. A second but related difference is the amount of time needed to make a decision. MP2
- 9 i. With top-down management, employees are more likely to have a negative attitude because they do not understand or like their work.
- 1 j. Top-down and bottom-up management are two very different ways of running a business. differences
- 3 k. In the top-down approach, the owner of a small company, for example, is completely in charge of all decision-making.

TRANSITION SIGNALS FOR CONTRAST

This chart shows transition signals that you can use to express differences. The rules, explanations, and examples that follow add to what you learned in Chapter 4 and Chapter 7.

SIGNALS TO SHOW DIFFERENCES			
Sentence Connectors	Coordinating Conjunctions	Subordinating Conjunctions	Others
in contrast	but	while	different(ly) from
on the other hand	yet	whereas	unlike
however		although	differ (from) (in)
/Nevertheless		even though	
/Still/		though	
Nonetheless			

Sentence Connectors

In contrast, on the other hand, and however can be used as synonyms.

In Great Britain, the letter *a* in the words *path, laugh, aunt* and *plant* is pronounced like the /a/ sound in *father*. In the United States, **in contrast / on the other hand / however**, the letter *a* in the same words is pronounced like the /a/ sound you hear in *cat*.

*In the Us, the letter a....., however.
However, in the Us, the letter a.....*

Coordinating Conjunctions

Use *but* when the ideas are exact opposites.

College classes are pre-university level in Great Britain, **but** they are university level in the United States.

Use *yet* when one idea is a surprising or unexpected continuation of the other idea. It is also possible to use *but*.

All in all, students of English will notice the differences between the language used in Britain and in the United States, **yet** they are still learning the same language.

Subordinating Conjunctions

Use *while* and *whereas* when the ideas are exact opposites. *While* and *whereas* can begin either clause. Always use a comma even when the independent clause comes first. This is an exception to the usual rule.

British students *theorise, analyse, and socialise*, **while** *whereas* American students *theorize, analyze, and socialize*.

While

Whereas British students *theorise, analyse, and socialise*, American students *theorize, analyze, and socialize*.

Use *although, even though, or though* when one idea is a surprising or unexpected continuation of the other idea.

Americans sometimes have difficulties traveling or living in England **although** they speak English.

even though/though

Although they speak English, Americans sometimes have difficulties traveling or living in England.

Despite/In spite of + Ving (same subject)

Others

+ Noun/Noun Phrase

From and *unlike* are both prepositions. Put a noun or noun phrase after them.

The way Americans pronounce the word *better* **is** **different** **from** the way British people do.

Unlike the British, Americans pronounce the *t* in *better* and *butter* as a /d/ sound.

Differently is an adverb. It describes the verb *say* in the following example.

Americans say many words differently from the way the British do.

Differ is a verb.

American English and British English differ in pronunciation.

American biscuits and British biscuits differ.

AE differs/is different/ works differently from BE in pronunciation

PRACTICE 9

Using Contrast Signals

Write contrast sentences using the given information. Use a sentence connector, a coordinating conjunction, and a subordinating conjunction.

1. England is a small country. It used to have colonies around the world.

- England is a small country. However, it used to have colonies around the world.
- England is a small country, but it used to have colonies around the world.
- Although England is a small country, it used to have colonies around the world.

2. American colonists spoke British English in the 1600s and 1700s. Differences in American English and British English are quite obvious now.

- _____ However,
- _____
- _____

3. Thousands of words still have the same meaning in British and American English. Some words do not mean the same thing at all.

- _____ yet
- _____
- _____

4. Biscuits are popular in the United States and Britain. They do not look or taste alike.

- _____
- Despite being popular.. britian, biscuits do not
- Despite their popularity.....Britain, biscuits do not....

5. American biscuits are a type of soft flaky bread baked in round shapes. British biscuits are hard, often have a sweet filling, and come in various shapes.

- _____
- Unlike American biscuits which are a type.....shapes, British ones are hard.....shapes.
- _____

6. In British cars, the *driving wheel* is on the right. In American cars, the *steering wheel* is on the left.

- British cars differ from American ones in that
- while the former has the driving wheel on the right, the latter
- has steering wheel on the left.

The driving wheel in B cars differs from the steering wheel in A ones in that while the former is on the right, the latter is on the left.

however

However,

yet

yet

Despite

Despite being popular.. britian, biscuits do not

Despite their popularity.....Britain, biscuits do not....

Unlike A which/who..., B.....

Unlike American biscuits which are a type.....shapes, British ones are hard.....shapes.

A differs from B in that while the former....., the latter.....

British cars differ from American ones in that while the former has the driving wheel on the right, the latter has steering wheel on the left.

The driving wheel in B cars differs from the steering wheel in A ones in that while the former is on the right, the latter is on the left.

Grammar: The Comparative and Superlative

ADJECTIVES	
EXPLANATION	EXAMPLES
For one-syllable adjectives, add <i>-er</i> and <i>-est</i> to form the comparative and superlative forms. For two-syllable adjectives ending in <i>-y</i> , change the <i>y</i> to <i>i</i> , and add <i>-er</i> / <i>-est</i> .	Washington, DC, is cold in the winter. Boston is colder than Washington, DC. Quebec City is the coldest . Sudan is sunnier than Iceland.
Exceptions include <i>good</i> / <i>better</i> / <i>the best</i> and <i>bad</i> / <i>worse</i> / <i>the worst</i> .	Chicken is better than beef for a healthy heart, but salmon may be the best of all.
Adjectives of more than one syllable are preceded by <i>more</i> and <i>the most</i> to form the comparative and superlative.	Venice is more beautiful than Rome. Florence is the most beautiful city in Italy.
ADVERBS	
EXPLANATION	EXAMPLES
One-syllable adverbs follow the same rule as one-syllable adjectives.	The Shanghai Maglev train travels fast . The high-speed TGV train in France goes faster . The SCMaglev train in Japan goes the fastest .
Adverbs that end in <i>-ly</i> are preceded by <i>more</i> and <i>the most</i> .	Compared to fruits, people digest vegetables slowly . People digest meat more slowly than vegetables. We digest fats the most slowly of all foods.

Note: You can use “compared to” instead of “than” to sound more formal.

WITHIN A SENTENCE	EXAMPLES
compared to + noun	Tokyo is very large compared to Kyoto. (Tokyo is larger than Kyoto)



ACTIVITY 6 | Practice with comparatives and superlatives

Write the correct comparative or superlative form of the word in parentheses.

- Some people think Lionel Messi is a **better** (good) soccer player than Cristiano Ronaldo.
- A football field is **longer** (long) than a tennis court.
- Chess has **more difficult** (difficult) rules than checkers does.
- The **hottest** (hot) place in the United States is Death Valley, California.
- A birthday party is usually **more casual** (casual) than a wedding.

6. The final exam ended more quickly (quickly) than everyone anticipated.
7. The most impressive (impressive) highway system in the world is Germany's Autobahn.
8. The worst (bad) cup of coffee Miguel has ever tasted was in the university cafeteria.
9. Aomori City in Japan is the world's snowiest (snowy) city.
10. Australia is roughly the same (same) size as the United States.

PRACTICE 11 Using Antonyms

Read the sentences. Find an antonym from the box for each boldface word. Then complete each sentence with the correct antonym and a thought of your own. Use a dictionary as needed.

clear ignore individually ~~major~~ succeed

1. Technology played a **minor** role in education 50 years ago. However,
computers are a major part of education today.

2. Students who **fail** often wait until the day before a test to study. In contrast,
Those who succeed will set a clear schedule for revision.
will review the contents carefully after each lesson.

3. In many classes, students work **together** on group projects, but
in some other classes, they are asked to work individually.

4. It is important for students to **look at** tests and assignments carefully when their instructors return their papers. They should never **ignore**
even the most marginal comments for improvement.

5. Although some things about English are still **confusing** to me,
most of the things about it seem clear enough.

WRITING PRACTICE

*Write a paragraph to analyze the differences between **working from home and working at the office**. In your opinion, which method is a more effective one?*